



Switch VR headset

A gamer and YouTuber, Nintendrew put up a video of how on how he made his own VR headset for the Switch. <http://digit.in/VRswitch>



End corporate dominance

Blockstack, an open-sourced project is trying to address some of the fundamental problems with internet. <http://digit.in/Blockstack>

How We Tested

We've been tweaking our test process over the past half year or so, designing a better way to test every possible aspect of phones today. For example, wide angle or dual-cameras get extra points on our score sheets today, while the suite of benchmarks we used has increased too (more on that in a bit).

To start with, our reviews of each of these devices figure into this comparison. So, things such as design and build quality have been tested during that process. Each phone has been put through at least a week's worth of regular usage, to

ascertain kinks in regular usability and get the reviewer's subjective opinion in for all of them. Of course, our tests are still as objective as ever, but the subjective opinion sort of makes up the cherry on top of the cake.

The suite of benchmarks are run multiple times, both on a SIM free just out of the box phone, and then on one that has all SIM services running. We also try performance tests with variable load, meaning the apps loaded onto the device are carefully chosen and the same apps are used on all phones. Asphalt 8, WWE Champions and Injustice: Gods Among Us are our games of choice

for testing gaming scores, and the frame rates on each are carefully recorded.

For heating issues, we test each phone over 10 minutes of 4K video recording, noting down both internal and external temperatures. An HTC Instruments heat gun is used for heat tests, one that has been uniformly used on all our test devices. Heat readings are also noted after half an hour's gameplay on the games mentioned above.

Rounding up the performance tests are the suite of benchmarks, including AnTuTu, Geekbench 4, GFXBench (Car Chase), 3D Mark (Slingshot and Unlimited) and Mobile XPRT.

An HTC Instruments luminance meter is used to measure display luminance readings, while pre-selected

high quality images are used to compare displays side-by-side. Colour, contrast ratios, saturation and brightness are all taken into account when testing displays.

To test the battery, we use PC Mark's Work 2.0 battery test, which simulates everything from web browsing to video. It records the time taken to bring the battery down from 80% to 20%, which is where smartphone batteries are at their best. PC Mark's test simulates real world usage quite well, but our regular usage patterns also figure into battery tests.

Lastly, a smartphone's camera is carefully tested by taking exactly the same shots with all cameras. The same is done over varying light conditions and then compared side-by-side on a pre-calibrated display.

OTHER FEATURES

IT'S AI GALORE this year, with Google appearing on pretty much every MWC presentation. We haven't actively compared the AI on these devices though, because we do not think they're ready to be features worth considering right now. For example, Samsung's Bixby assistant is an unfinished product right now, with limited capabilities, especially in India.

The Google Assistant on the LG G6 is more evolved, but as was our experience on the Pixel smartphones, there's nothing special here. It's innovative software for sure, but we wouldn't expect it to make a big difference in your buying decision just yet. In fact, the Xperia XZs still has Google Now On Tap instead. The LG G6 is worth recommending to audio enthusiasts, with better audio quality compared to its competitors. If you have good enough headphones, the 32-bit Hi-Fi DAC will help get better audio quality than on most smartphones.

BEST PERFORMER

While it definitely has its flaws, the Samsung Galaxy S8 is the best performer amongst these three smartphones. In terms of looks the Samsung Galaxy S8 is definitely the best looking smartphone in the market today. The phone is noticeably faster than the other two and has a real edge in terms of shooting photos in low light. The screen complements all of this, and a unique and attractive design is the icing on the cake. The Samsung Galaxy S8 combined flagship class design with some of the best smartphone hardware out there. Given that Samsung is working on the Galaxy Note 8 too, we wonder how the company can top this device. 



Samsung Galaxy S8